

BEING LEFT OUT

Communists are increasingly losing their traditional social base to new challengers

Marx is withering away in the countryside. The erosion of communist parties' social base is getting alarmingly starker in both West Bengal and Kerala, the last but shaky citadels of the Left. In the state that first elected the communists in a historic popular vote, militarised Dalits are taking on the comrades in an armed struggle. In Bengal, Mamata Banerjee has replaced the communists in many parts of the hinterland as the saviour of the shirtless. In the last general election, the Left's tally fell from a mighty 61 to a humble 24. The civic polls in Bengal completed the communist humiliation. The share of workers among trade unions of the CPI(M)'s once powerful trade union arm, the CITU, has shrunk from 14.55 per cent to 10.88 per cent.

After reaping early political rewards by implementing land reforms, the Left got caught in a time warp. Despite its tired rhetoric on the marginalised, the comrades have no salvation formula that can sway the dispossessed. The land acquisition fiasco in Singur and Nandigram mercilessly splintered its traditional support base. And the cow belt remains immune to the CPI(M)'s slogans. The CPI has been reduced to a party of lesser comrades overshadowed by Big Brother CPI(M), which is no longer a party of lily-white idealists. A rectification campaign is being planned to change the party root and branch. It vows to check the trend of "comrades becoming rich overnight". Such paperwork may keep the apparatchiks of AKG Bhavan busy, but in West Bengal and Kerala, new revolutionaries are stealing the thunder—and the masses—from the party that has internalised the worst instincts of a redundant ideology.

by Shafi Rahman